leap to space. All that, however, would become clear to me only after my own incarceration and eventual acquittal.

The crafty tales of a foreign agency's collaborators in India's IB fly in the face of the commitment and delivery of Reddy's company towards Indian space and nuclear science. MTAR, which also made the solid propellant machining facilities, was soon to become one of the most reliable partners of ISRO. MTAR, along with Godrej, continues to make almost the entire Vikas engine for PSLV which has had more than thirty consecutively successful flight including the moon and mars missions.

When Ravindra Reddy passed away in January 2016, MTAR noted in a press release that the Department of Atomic Energy had fully trusted the company as it acquired the capabilities of building a nuclear reactor entirely on its own. Reddy, who served on the board of ISRO's commercial arm Antrix Corporation (Ratan Tata and Adi Godrej were among the other members), won the Prime Minister's Defence Technology Absorption Award in 2004.

It was not always big industrialists like Reddy who vied for ISRO contracts. I would give just anyone the chance to collaborate. An example was Alwar Metal Industries, which was nothing more than a workshop at Aryasala in Trivandrum when we gave it a contract in the early 1970s.

It was to make a pyro valve for the three-tonne liquid engine that we were developing for the second stage of the Rohini-560 rocket. The contraption was to work thus—a charge when fired would generate high pressure that punctures a diaphragm, allowing the liquid fuel to flow in on direction. Once this flow is established, the valve would remain open.

Tenders were called from big companies including Larsen & Toubro which quoted Rs 9,000 per piece. Responding to a newspaper advertisement, Alwar Metal Industries also filed a bid. Quoting a little more than Rs 300 a piece, it was the lowest bid. I was astonished how they could make the pyro valve for so less. I asked the company owner to meet me.

Alwar, a 60-something man, said, 'Don't worry about the quality of the valve, you may test it and if rejected, don't pay me a rupee.'